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## **Values, Perceptions, Conceptions, and Peacebuilding: A Qualitative Case Study of a Mexican Business**

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### **Abstract**

The direct assault on criminal organizations by the Mexican government has not resulted in a more peaceful country, a circumstance that continues to impact people's sentiments about their safety. In previous studies, this research team qualitatively explored the social construction of perceptions regarding organized criminal violence and peace in Mexico. Personal experiences and observations were found to be the main social constructors of participant perceptions of criminal violence and peace. This paper represents the continuation of that research and involved 25 participants employed in a private corporation ranked as one of the top companies to work for in Mexico. We explored any variations between these participants and the initial 80 participants in the previous study. The results indicate that the patterns tend to repeat, suggesting that despite offering economic and labor incentives, training, and education programs, as well as taking other measures to establish a favorable working atmosphere, when the surrounding environment in which workers live is violent, those incentives may not be sufficient to generate overall positive peaceful sentiments among them. Only a comprehensive approach to peacebuilding may be

effective in producing a change in worker perceptions regarding organized criminal violence and the possibilities for peace in their country.

## **VALUES, PERCEPTIONS, CONCEPTIONS, AND PEACEBUILDING: A QUALITATIVE CASE STUDY OF A MEXICAN BUSINESS**

### **Introduction**

The Mexican government's direct assault on criminal organizations has not resulted in a more peaceful country. In its 2016 edition, the Global Peace Index ranked Mexico among the 25 least peaceful countries on Earth (IEP, 2016), dropping six spots since the previous edition. The environment of violence has had a profound impact on Mexicans' perceptions of their security, on the state of their fear, and on their views regarding the possibility of establishing peace in Mexico in the near future (Buendía & Laredo, 2010; Consulta Mitofsky, 2011).

The first stage of this project was conducted by one of the authors on this research team as his dissertation project (Meschoulam 2014). The second stage involved 80 participants, representing different genders, ages, and professions, living in various parts of the country, who were interviewed about their perceptions of violence and peace. In that study, the research team (Meschoulam et al., 2015) found that the manner by which research participants formed ideas and perceptions regarding organized criminal violence and peace was based primarily on their own experiences, their conversations, and the experiences of people closely related to them, and less on their connections to mass media. In fact, participants tended to distrust mass media, considering it part of a corrupt system. It was through those own experiences, observations, and conversations that participants concluded that peace in Mexico would be achievable in the future only by addressing the structural and systemic factors that are the root causes of organized crime. In the view of participants, this long-term approach would have to include actions such as combating corruption, fostering education, and reducing economic and social inequalities in the country. The authors concluded that structural factors should be not only addressed at the federal level but also emphasized as part of a local approach to positively impact people's experiences and observations.

This paper presents the continuation of the work of this research team (Meschoulam et al., 2015) by involving participants who work in a private corporation, ranked one of the top companies to work for in Mexico. This ranking is due to the company's favorable working conditions and socially responsible actions, and the incentives it provides for employees. The objective of this qualitative study was to explore whether 25 employees of one socially responsible company presented any variations in contrast to participants from the previous study (Meschoulam et al., 2015), in the way they socially construct their sentiments and ideas about the conditions of their country, its future, or the possibility of establishing peace in Mexico. We wanted to understand whether their personal experiences at work made a difference on those perceptions, and to what degree this was evident to those interviewees.

This paper presents the findings of the third stage of the project and will begin by addressing the background and conceptual framework of the case study, including a summary of results from the

previous two stages of the project and a brief literature review on the role of for-profit corporations in peacebuilding. The methodology will then be described to present the findings, discussion, and some notes on the implications of those findings for businesses and policymaking.

### **Background and Conceptual Framework: Business and Peacebuilding**

Literature covering the relationship between business and peacebuilding and the role of businesses in peacebuilding is rather vast. Based on their studies of environments in which there is an active war or an armed conflict situation to research on countries such as Colombia or Mexico, where organized criminal activities interfere with economic security and the business environment, several authors seem to agree about the growing role of corporations as responsible elements of the systems of which they are part. Bennett (2002) explained that corporations usually avoid security operations associated with peacekeeping. However, as the author noted, globalization is causing the role of the private sector to become increasingly more relevant in efforts to establish stability and security, as those factors directly affect the performance of private sector businesses. Therefore, in the author's view, corporations now share a role in the social responsibility for keeping peace, maintaining stability, and avoiding conflict.

Nevertheless, peace is not only the absence of violence (Alger, 1987; Galtung, 1985). According to Ekanola (2012), there must be different conditions, some objective and some subjective, for a society to be considered peaceful. Objective conditions include physical security, material prosperity, and harmony among the members of that society. Subjective conditions include the emotional wellbeing of the members of that society, the subject of extensive consideration in the three phases of the present investigation. Czerw (2014) made the distinction that:

Social well-being refers to life in bigger groups and societies to which we are not as attached as to family and friends. It is connected to the satisfaction obtained from belonging to a given society, the emotions experienced in that society or the sense of integration with the society, the acceptance and of own social environment, the sense of own contribution to the society, the sense of purpose of social environment development and the sense of coherence in the society [...] Employee well-being is defined as the assessment of one's own professional life in the context of evaluation of both job type and social professional environment. (p. 98)

The Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP, 2015) presented pillars of positive peace that include a well-functioning government, low levels of corruption, equitable distribution of income, and a sound environment for business. Therefore, as Bennett (2002) stated, corporations must work in collaboration with their governments and social organizations, and use their commercial and financial capabilities to foster stability in the surroundings where they operate. It must be recognized that as businesses have become more influential in their environments and in the lives of their workers, they have also become more socially responsible, acknowledging that labor contributes not only to the personal well-being of workers but also to a better society (Uccello, 2009). Some companies may do so because they care for their societies and are responsible actors;

others, may behave responsibly because it is profitable or because they fear the moral or economic damage that can be inflicted upon them should it be known that they do not behave responsibly.

In their investigation of a specific case of a company in Colombia, Azuero, García, and Duque (2012) noted that a corporation may have primary responsibilities, such as those inherent to their activities, secondary responsibilities, such as improving the impact of their business to their workers and their communities, and tertiary responsibilities, which relate to improving their environment. Thus, the private sector is seen by different authors as a resource that can contribute to building the conditions required for a durable and stable peace in societies with armed conflicts or criminal organizations, such as Colombia or Mexico (Jiménez, 2014). In some cases, corporations may have larger budgets, more capacity, more managerial expertise, and more knowledge than governments—all of which can contribute to peacebuilding. Not only do corporations create job opportunities, they also often have an apolitical nature. Thus, businesses “in theory, may be capable of acting where others can’t” (Berdal, 2010, p. 44).

Different authors provide examples of such contributions by corporations, such as the case of Nestlé. In Colombia, Nestlé works in collaboration with the Foundation for Reconciliation to create spaces for forgiveness, reconciliation, and peace, and to improve living conditions in areas in which the company operates (Jiménez, 2014). Additional authors have noted other roles corporations may play in peacebuilding: from roles in post-conflict situations (Berdal, 2010) to roles in active armed conflicts or other circumstances that occur in places where organized crime operates, such as in Colombia or Mexico (Arredondo, Rosas, & Villa, 2011).

Alger (2007) noted the potential role of business in conflict prevention and conflict management, while other scholars wrote about how business plays a role in fostering human rights and ethical behavior (Dubach & Machado, 2012) and in promoting education, health, and security (Wolf & Engert, 2005). Some companies fund projects to help marginalized or high-risk populations (Nelson, Jane, & Jenkins, 2005). Arredondo, Rosas, and Villa (2011) focused on studying programs for volunteers to improve the quality of life experienced within the company during labor hours.

On the topic of violence, Wennman (2012) advocated for involving corporations in violence reduction and prevention through proactive strategies to make businesses responsible for the zones in which they are located. Wennman mentioned the need to have enough information to analyze the causes and consequences of violence on multiple levels, including on people and communities. However, he also proposed multidimensional responses, as no single actor can do that job by itself. These additional actors include other corporations and other social sectors, such as the government. Taking a different perspective, Alger (2007) explained that peace is not a condition that can be created by governments alone. Just as non-governmental or social organizations must be involved, corporations too must assume their role in fostering the conditions required to build peace. All these actors are interdependent. In Alger’s view, researchers must work with businesses and inform them about their potential to contribute to peace. The question remains: “How can researchers

more adequately study these peace building roles and evaluate their effectiveness?" (Alger, 2007, p. 551).

There appears to be a lack of qualitative studies in Mexico that explore the impact positive labor experiences might have on the social construction process of violence and peace among workers. The present investigation intends to contribute to filling that gap.

### **Values, Perceptions, and Peacebuilding: Phases 1 and 2**

The first two stages of this project were based on a social constructivist approach (Assmann, 2008; Fagan, 2010; Stenmark, 2009). According to that approach, realities, such as violence or peace, or for that matter, the ability to change them, are constructed by the process of human interactions. In the field of public policy, social constructivists argue that underlying "assumptions, values, norms, rationales, social understandings, and shared knowledge about realities within human groups" (Schneider & Ingram, 1993) inform policy issues and design. Thus, understanding how such values, norms, and ideas are socially constructed is important, not only for policy makers and public administrators but also for society as a whole.

With that in mind, this research team (Meschoulam, 2014; Meschoulam et al., 2015) conducted the first and second stages of a research project seeking to explore the process through which participants from different places in Mexico socially constructed their values, perceptions, and conceptions regarding organized crime-related violence and peace in their country. Eighty qualitative interviews were conducted in 29 different neighborhoods in Mexico City and in 13 other states within Mexico. Consistent responses and pattern repetition emerged, despite differences in gender, age, profession, and location. According to those results, participants tended to socially construct their values, perceptions, and conceptions regarding organized crime-related violence and peace primarily on the following elements:

- (a) Individual experiences and observations;
- (b) Conversations with family, friends, neighbors, coworkers, and associates; and
- (c) The experiences of those in close proximity.

Participants showed distrust of traditional mass media, which was linked to expressions of distrust of the government. In the participant view, there is a deeply corrupted system in which a perverse circle is formed among the government, criminal organizations, and mass media. For this reason, even though most of them have some contact with newspapers, radio, or TV, most participants expressed that they do not feel influenced by those elements. Fear and terror stood out as some of the most frequently mentioned categories among participants who live outside Mexico City, which may be a result of the high rates of violence in those places.

The present case study is an expansion of the previous two phases of the project, and it was designed to explore a very specific type of environment: a corporation that not only contributes to the development of its society through socially responsible measures but is also regarded by its workers as a very favorable place to work. As Arredondo, Rosas, and Villa (2011) noted, in

Mexico, there are few companies that engage in integrating activities. Businesses are focused mainly on contributing through donations or by funding social projects. This is why the target company, which from this point will be called Company X for confidentiality reasons, was worthy of study.

### **The Company X**

The following information is obtained from the company's website and personal communication with company personnel. For confidentiality reasons, the sources cannot be cited. Company X has been rated as one of the best 50 Mexican corporations for the past three consecutive years. This recognition is awarded to private Mexican corporations by the Deloitte firm, with the support of the Mexican National Bank and the Technological Institute of Monterrey. This distinction is granted to companies that exhibit high performance in business management and have good business practices in areas such as sustainability, investment in human capital, leadership, planning, and operation. Company X also received the Gilberto Rincón Gallardo Award for Inclusive Companies in 2013, 2014, and 2015, which recognizes private organizations using practices designed to integrate people in vulnerable situations, and promote diversity and inclusion. The company also received the Super Empresas Expansión award, which is granted following a survey of an organization's employees regarding working conditions and motivation. The company is then audited by a firm specializing in human resources to verify the practices and procedures the corporation uses. Finally, Company X has received the Social Responsibility Award from the Mexican Center of Philanthropy and the Alliance for Corporate Social Responsibility.

One of the priorities of Company X is to retain its personnel and aid in their personal development. Therefore, several corporate training programs and personal coaching at all levels are available. Executives are trained in business management practices such as personnel evaluation and monetary and non-monetary development incentives. Company X receives continuous feedback from its workers regarding its organizational culture and atmosphere. It promotes ethical behavior by providing direct contact with the Deloitte firm for workers who wish to report suspected unethical situations.

Company X develops training workshops on topics of inclusion, sustainability, and community aid. It has a track team, and it also has an internal school where workers can complete their basic studies after work. There is transportation service for workers and a dining room in which employees pay only a small sum to obtain high-quality nutritious meals. Company X provides a favorable environment for its workers, well above average among Mexican businesses.

### **Research Question**

The research question that guides this study is as follows: What are the processes by which values, perceptions, and conceptions regarding the current state of organized criminal violence and peace possibilities for Mexico are socially constructed among 25 people who work in a very favorable environment? Assuming that personal experiences and observations were the main social constructs underlying perceptions and conceptions of criminal violence and peace among the

participants in the previous phases of the investigation, we wondered what variations might be encountered between those initial 80 participants and the 25 people who work in a very favorable environment, in terms of their social-construction process. This study also explored the role government and criminal organizations played in participant perceptions regarding organized criminal violence and peace possibilities for Mexico, the role of mass media, and the role of oral conversation in the process of social construction.

## **Methodology**

This study was conducted through qualitative deep interviews with 25 participants who work in Company X.

### *Setting*

The country of Mexico consists of 31 states and one federal district. The data collection took place in Company X, located in the State of Mexico (Estado de México), the state that surrounds Mexico City. Company X provided interviewers with time and designated quiet places where interviews could be conducted in comfortable privacy.

### *Participants and sampling strategy*

A combination of purposive sampling and random sampling strategies were used to select the participants. The sample was designed to represent, as much as possible, the demographic patterns and income levels within the company. Of the 25 participants, 14 were women and 11 were men, which represents the gender composition of Company X. Seeking to represent the age composition of the corporation, we interviewed seven individuals under 24 years of age, 17 people between 25 and 59 years old, and one person above the age of 59. The company has 258 employees, of which 32% are considered low income, 59% are middle income, and 9% are high income or executives. Thus, the sample consisted of 8 low-income participants, 14 middle-income participants, and 3 high-income participants or executives. The sample is not intended to be representative of the Mexican population or of socio-demographic patterns in Mexico. The procedures for contacting, recruiting, and conducting the research adhered to the ethical standards used in previous studies conducted by this research team, already published in 2014 and 2015, which are in compliance with Mexican law regarding the privacy and security of information and data. All the participants signed informed consent forms.

### *Data collection*

Data collection consisted of 25 face-to-face deep interviews conducted under safe and comfortable conditions. The interviews were all conducted in Spanish, the native language of the participants. The same semi-structured interview protocol that was used for the previous phases noted above was applied. This was of particular importance since the purpose of the study was to explore potential differences in responses and pattern repetitions between participants of this study and participants from previous phases of the project. Variations of the questions were used only to obtain further details. All the interviews were digitally recorded. Notes and signal elements from the interviews were also used.

*Data analysis*

As in the first two phases of the project, interviews in the present study were transcribed and analyzed using *NVivo* qualitative data management software. All the categories used for the first and second phases of the project, whether preexisting or emerging, were now treated as preexisting themes. Because of the nature of the present case study, three additional categories were precoded, paying close attention to whether those specific themes were mentioned by the participants: *Positive strategy/Government efficiency*, *Positive experience at work*, and *Situation improving*. Attention was also paid to the potential emergence of new themes. Words, sentences, or paragraphs were encoded according to these categories to detect patterns and repetitions. Table 1 shows the preexisting categories.

*Table 1. Preexisting categories*

| <b>Social Constructors:<br/>Experience/Observation/Conversation</b>             | <b>Social Constructors<br/>Mass Media</b>                    | <b>Social<br/>Constructors:<br/>Other</b>               | <b>Perceptions and<br/>conceptions: Causes<br/>of violence and<br/>solutions for<br/>peacebuilding</b> |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Experience of someone close</i>                                              | <i>Printed</i>                                               | <i>Family social construction</i>                       |                                                                                                        |
| <i>Experience at work</i>                                                       | <i>TV</i>                                                    | <i>Education and learning social construction</i>       | <i>Structural peace conception</i>                                                                     |
| <i>Positive experience at work</i>                                              | <i>Radio</i>                                                 | <i>Religion social construction</i>                     | <i>Education as a peacebuilding factor/education investment</i>                                        |
| <i>One specific experience</i>                                                  | <i>Movies</i>                                                | <i>Old age social construction</i>                      | <i>Structural violence conception</i>                                                                  |
| <i>Oral conversation</i>                                                        | <i>Distrust of Mass Media</i>                                | <i>Books social construction</i>                        | <i>Grassroots peace conception</i>                                                                     |
| <i>Excessive violence (high-impact violence or terrorist tactics)</i>           | <i>Little or very little contact with mass media,</i>        | <i>Cultural social construction</i>                     | <i>Government not succeeding/not efficient/negligent</i>                                               |
| <i>Fear or terror</i>                                                           | <i>Music or Cultural programs in General</i>                 | <i>Public spaces interaction social construction</i>    | <i>Positive strategy/Government efficiency</i>                                                         |
| <i>Security forces out in the streets cause stress or impact my perceptions</i> | <i>They exhibit too many violent images or stories</i>       | <i>Social or political meetings social construction</i> | <i>Distrust of government</i>                                                                          |
| <i>Frustration/Impotence</i>                                                    | <i>Analysis programs are interesting</i>                     |                                                         | <i>Corruption</i>                                                                                      |
|                                                                                 | <i>Not Interesting</i>                                       |                                                         | <i>Lack of family care or lack of parents' care</i>                                                    |
|                                                                                 | <i>I used to watch (read/listen) to them but not anymore</i> |                                                         | <i>Participation/engagement as citizens in public issues</i>                                           |
|                                                                                 | <i>Internet social construction</i>                          |                                                         |                                                                                                        |
|                                                                                 | <i>Social media</i>                                          |                                                         |                                                                                                        |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |  | <i>Ambition/Crime is easy money</i><br><i>Situation deteriorating</i><br><i>Situation improving</i><br><i>Mexicans are naturally violent</i><br><i>Mexico or Mexicans are passive (do not act or engage)</i><br><i>Loss of values</i><br><i>Lack of social interaction, lack of links</i><br><i>Mexicans are naturally peaceful</i><br><i>My hometown is less violent than other places</i> |
| <b>Perceptions and Conceptions related to Peace</b><br><br><i>Peace understood as links and relations</i><br><i>Peace understood as respect for or absence of violence/not “messaging” with one another</i><br><i>Peace understood as tranquility, calmness, Inner peace</i><br><i>Peace not related to poverty or underdevelopment</i><br><i>Peace is possible / Peace is not possible or too difficult</i><br><i>Mexico is not peaceful</i><br><i>Mexico is peaceful</i> | <b>Perceptions and Conceptions related to Organized Crime (OC)</b><br><br><i>Tough approach to OC/we should not negotiate</i><br><i>OC too powerful</i><br><i>OC normalized (OC is part of Mexican life), Long-term problem (Participant believes violence is a long-term problem)</i><br><i>OC an international problem</i><br><i>OC not violent/lives in peace within communities</i> |  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

|                                                              |  |  |  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--|--|--|
| <i>Principles and values<br/>as components of<br/>peace,</i> |  |  |  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--|--|--|

Consistent with the first and second studies, some of these themes appeared frequently in the participant discourse, whereas some appeared only a few times.

### *Trustworthiness*

Several triangulation methods were used to ensure the trustworthiness of the results. Interviews were conducted by four different members of the team who had experience using the protocol. The identified patterns and repetitions were confirmed, even though the interviews were conducted by different interviewers. Second, a peer-review process was used in which data were shared with all team members, and group discussions were held to minimize personal biases. As evidence grew that this study was producing results that were very similar to those of the previous two studies, more meetings with the team were held to ensure that all researchers/interviewers were paying close attention to any variations or differences. Finally, following the data analysis, all the categories and their frequencies were contrasted to the first and second stages of the project to determine whether the patterns were consistent with or different from the results from the previous studies.

### *Transferability*

The first two stages of this research provided results for 80 participants who lived in very different areas of Mexico City and in various regions of the country. In this third stage, we added 25 additional interviews with participants who work in a favorable business environment. However, neither the first two studies nor the present case study intend to produce results that could be generalized to the entirety of the Mexican population. The samples are small and limited. Moreover, findings from the present study cannot be immediately generalized to all workers in the target company. Nevertheless, the consistency of pattern repetition among the participants, who represent very different locations and professions, and the consistency of the results across different genders, ages, and working environments strengthen the hypothesis suggested by this research team (Meschoulam et al., 2015), which should be tested through further research in Mexico or elsewhere.

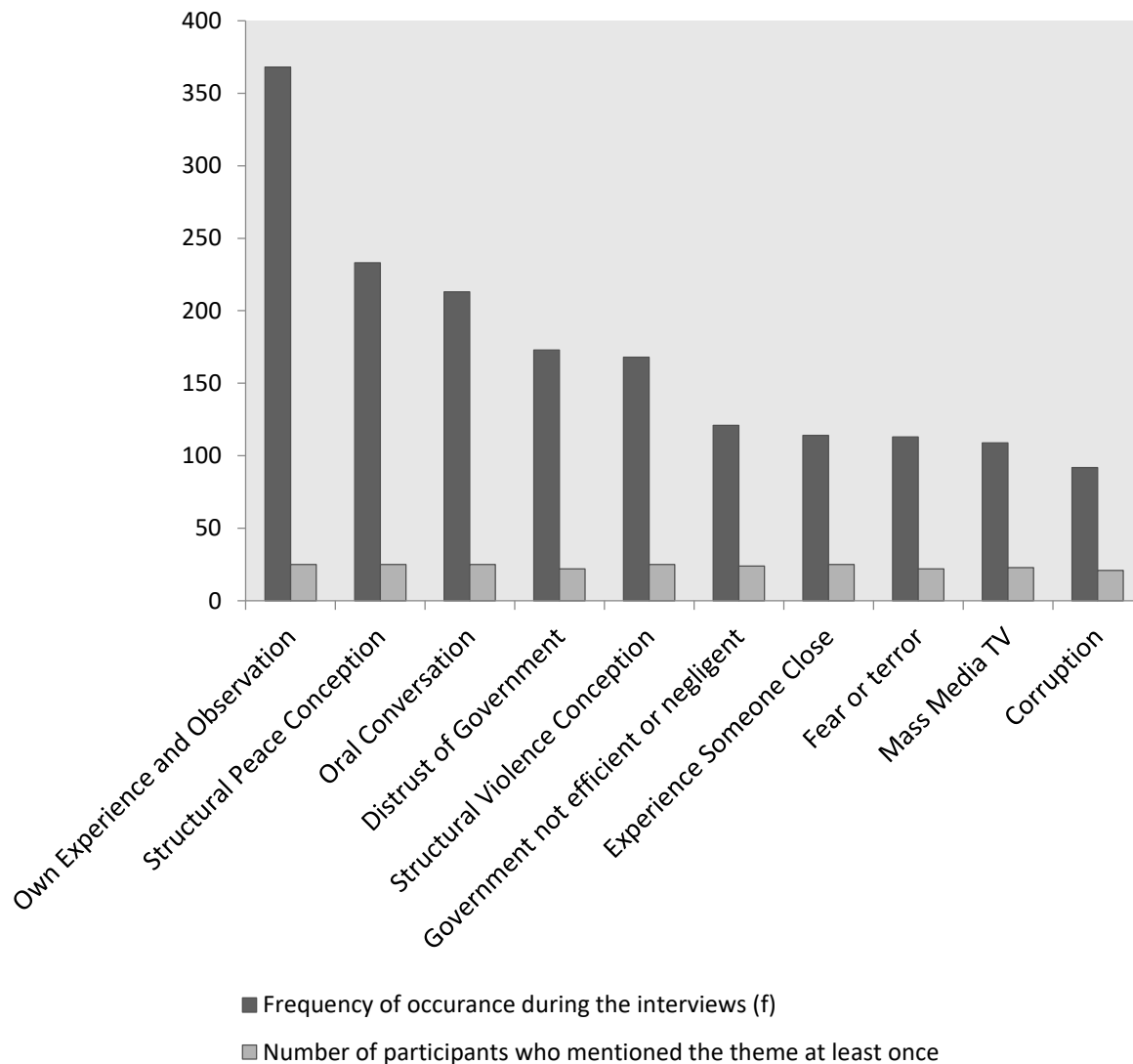
## **Results**

The patterns from phases 1 and 2 of the project (Meschoulam 2014; Meschoulam et al., 2015) tend to repeat among the 25 interviewed workers of Company X. The most frequently occurring themes among the 25 interviews were *Experience and personal observation*, *Structural peace conception*, and *Oral conversation*; each of these themes was mentioned by all the participants. A general overview of the most frequent themes is provided in Table 2.

*Table 2. Ten most frequently occurring themes; Total participants: 25*

| <b>Categories coded</b>                      | <b>Frequency of occurrence during the interviews (f)</b> | <b>Number of participants who mentioned the theme at least once</b> |
|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Own Experience and Observation</b>        | 368                                                      | 25                                                                  |
| <b>Structural Peace Conception</b>           | 233                                                      | 25                                                                  |
| <b>Oral Conversation</b>                     | 213                                                      | 25                                                                  |
| <b>Distrust of Government</b>                | 173                                                      | 22                                                                  |
| <b>Structural Violence Conception</b>        | 168                                                      | 25                                                                  |
| <b>Government Not Efficient or Negligent</b> | 121                                                      | 24                                                                  |
| <b>Experience of Someone Close</b>           | 114                                                      | 25                                                                  |
| <b>Fear or Terror</b>                        | 113                                                      | 22                                                                  |
| <b>Mass Media TV</b>                         | 109                                                      | 23                                                                  |
| <b>Corruption</b>                            | 92                                                       | 21                                                                  |

Figure 1: Overall frequencies. This graph shows the saturation of the first 10 categories.



### General overview and contrasts

#### i) Experience, personal observation, and oral conversation

*Experience and personal observation* was the most frequently mentioned theme by the 25 participants ( $f=368$  or 14% of all mentions). Oral conversation was the second ( $f=213$  or 8% of all mentions). The seventh most frequently mentioned category was *Experience of someone close* ( $f=114$  or 4.3% of all mentions). These patterns confirm the tendency found in previous phases of the project. Participants in this investigation tend to socially construct their values, perceptions, and conceptions of organized crime-related violence and peace mainly from their own experiences; from social conversations they have with family, friends, coworkers, or associates; and from the

experiences of people close to them. Following are some typical responses related to those categories:

I tell you, we live it; nobody has told us about it [...] One time, they even came in to search...I don't know whether it was the drug dealers, it seems to me they were because they carried heavy weapons [...]. They came into my house because they were searching for one of the drug distributors from my neighborhood, one who lived in the same building where I live [...]. They came in that night. It was 4 am, we were sleeping [...] and they came in kicking doors [...] and they opened my door with a kick. That is how we find about these things. Nobody tells us; we live it. (Interview participant 5)

Two years ago some people came in and assaulted me, and I didn't let them, I started fighting with them, and I got even with them [...] so then they grabbed a lady, one of them pulled out the gun, put it against my head and hit me with it, it was inside the subway, just imagine, and he got me sitting down and he shot me in the leg. Now you tell me whether there was a policeman around, no, there was no one. (Interview participant 10)

They were drinking and they mugged me, they hit me and sent me to the hospital for two months. They took my wallet, 80 pesos, my jacket, my tennis shoes, they broke some of my teeth, they damaged my ribs. (Interview participant 15)

Well, this is a little too frightening. One of my neighbors went out to work and she tells us her mother was on the phone with her boyfriend, she was going to work, she was in a taxi, and the boyfriend started to hear smashes and very ugly things (they were beating up a girl). The girl was screaming, and the girl disappeared for three days, and they found her dead inside a trashcan, so yes, it's too strong. (Interview participant 22)

In the basic school where my daughter goes, all the parents were called in because in the area of Azcapotzalco they were kidnapping children. We were told at school, I don't know whether these were urban stories, or whether they kidnapped a boy from the kindergarten, and they say they found his open body with no organs, and they left money for the parents in exchange for the organs. I don't know whether this happened or not, but the point is they told us. (Interview participant 4)

i) *Distrust of mass media and distrust of government*

Despite the fact that TV (f=109 or 4% of all mentions) appeared as a somewhat more frequently mentioned theme than in the previous phases of the study, other types of mass media such as radio (f=16) or printed media (f=28) were mentioned very few times during the interviews. Furthermore, *Distrust of mass media* (f=75) appeared repeatedly during the interviews. *Distrust of government* (f=173 or 6.5% of all mentions) was the fourth most frequently mentioned category, and *Government not efficient or negligent* (f=121 or 4.5% of all mentions) was also among the top 10 most frequently mentioned themes. When interpreting participant conversations, it appears, just as in the previous phases of this project, that even though they have contact with traditional mass

media, participants believe that these media sources are complicit with the government, which they generally do not trust. Thus, they tend to form their opinions and ideas from their own experiences, their conversations, and the experiences of closely related people, which represent sources that they do trust. As in the first two phases of the project, almost 50% of the total interview mentions relating to the social construction of values, perceptions, and ideas regarding organized criminal violence and peace consist of themes connected to experience (their own or someone close to them), whereas only 12% of the mentions are linked to traditional mass media (TV, radio, or papers). The following are some examples of such mentions:

Look, what I say of organized crime happens in the neighborhood where I live. Everybody knows who sells drugs, where they're distributed; the police patrols go by all the time, and they do nothing. We even know they sell drugs in the market; the kids walk by, and nobody can get in because we know someone is coming behind [...] and they walk by, and everybody knows, we all know what streets, we know who they are, and nobody does anything. (Interview participant 24)

No, I have never voted for the same reason; it would be like supporting the thieves, the ones who cheat you, the people who will rob you in the future and will make things worse. So, how can I trust people like that? (Interview participant 1)

I don't listen to the news because you know that what they tell you there, only half of it is true and half isn't. And you can't know which part is the truth and which is not. (Interview participant 10)

They (mass media) are sensationalist, you know they are not objective, and they do it to get better ratings; they make you see things as more violent they get your attention when they are actually not as critical as they say [...] so you trust half of what they say, and you distrust half. (Interview participant 11)

First of all, because media lives off its sales, it's a business, and they try to sell their stories to the highest bidder, and if the government pays them enough so they say what the government wants, well, they'll put it as the government wants it. (Interview participant 17)

## ii) *Structural peace and structural violence*

Consistent with the first two phases of the project (Meschoulam 2014; Meschoulam et al., 2015), the second most frequently mentioned category was *Structural peace conception* (f=233 or 8.6% of all mentions). This means that participants tend to perceive organized criminal violence as being rooted in structural factors. These factors include a lack of equal opportunities, a lack of social justice, and the structural weakness of institutions, among others. *Structural violence* (f=168 or 6.3% of all mentions) was the 5<sup>th</sup> most frequently occurring category. As in the previous studies, participants placed special emphasis on factors such as education as peacebuilders, grassroots participation (Alger, 1987), and the need to combat corruption to build peace in the future. The following are some examples:

Well, there are many people in need because they never studied. Not because they didn't want to, but because they didn't have resources to do it. And no job. Or the job they have doesn't provide enough to sustain their families. (Interview participant 22)

Most kids today are leaving school for the same reason. If it's not for drugs, it's because of lack of money at home; they have not enough resources to keep studying. (Interview participant 12)

It's the government, because if the government doesn't provide jobs, well, people seek out the easiest paths, right? Such as consuming drugs and selling drugs, weapons, and such things. (Interview participant 15)

Well, it's what we live, what we see, isn't it? Let's talk about salaries. The more you earn, the more they take from you. If people start doing more things and they don't have enough money, then they start doing other things. There is a lack of opportunities for people [...] the government doesn't provide the choice of good teachers, good schools, nothing. (Interview participant 18)

I think if the government was well organized and there was not so much corruption, we would not be going through what we are [...] Some cops just mugged a friend, so who do you really have to watch out for? (Interview participant 10)

Most of the participants (64%) believe that Mexico is not peaceful. However, the majority of them (56%) believe that peace can be built as long as structural factors are appropriately addressed:

The government has to be very intelligent. We can't go without a strategy; we can't go simply arresting people in the streets. We must have long-term strategies, beyond political parties, beyond terms, in which the true objective is recovering social peace and the rule of law. (Interview participant 7)

I want to believe peace is possible. But it will come slowly, things will not change right away. Organized crime took many years to be in the shape it is, and in the same way, we will reach peace only in the long term. (Interview participant 22)

### *Contrasting results with previous phases*

The results of the present case study were not found to be significantly different from the results of the previous phases of the project conducted by this research team (Meschoulam 2014; Meschoulam et al., 2015). With only one variation (explained below), the top eight most frequently occurring categories in this study are exactly the same as those that appeared in the previous phases. Several tests were conducted to detect pattern repetitions and variations between the different stages of the project. These tests included comparing (a) the overall results from stages 1 and 2 with the results of the present study; (b) the male and female participants in the present

study; (c) the male participants in this study with the male participants in the previous stages, as well as the female participants in the present study with the female participants in the previous stages; (d) participants of different ages in this study and participants of different ages in the previous phases of the project; and (e) participants with different income levels within Company X. In all cases, the three initial frequencies, as explained above, are exactly the same, and the first 10 categories remain very similar in all the phases of the project. Furthermore, although this qualitative study does not seek to identify any statistical significance, it is interesting to note the statistical similarities in the results from the present study of 25 workers from Company X and the results of the previous 80 interviews conducted in many different places in the country with people from very diverse professions and jobs. The category with the highest rate of occurrences in the previous study was *Experience and observation*, which represented 13.76% of all mentions, with 100% of the participants mentioning it at least once. In the present study, the most frequently mentioned theme is *Experience and observation* as well; it represented 13.72% of all mentions, and 100% of the participants mentioned it at least once. Something similar is true for the second and third most frequently occurring themes: *Structural peace conception* and *Oral conversation*. In the last stage of this project, those themes received 8.12% and 7.72% of all mentions, respectively, with 100% of the participants mentioning them at least once. Among the 25 Company X workers, those categories received 8.68% and 7.94% of all mentions, respectively, with 100% of the participants mentioning them at least once. Tables III, IV and V show the consistency of the pattern repetition among the participants in the different stages of the project.

*Table III. Four most frequently occurring concepts among the 15 participants in the initial study published in 2014*

| Categories coded                                                                       | Frequency of occurrence during the interviews (f) | Number of participants who mentioned the theme at least once |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Experience and personal observation</b>                                             | 111                                               | 15                                                           |
| <b>Structural peace conception (Peace possibility depends upon structural factors)</b> | 96                                                | 15                                                           |
| <b>Oral conversation</b>                                                               | 79                                                | 15                                                           |
| <b>Structural violence conception</b>                                                  | 64                                                | 14                                                           |

*Table IV. Four most frequently occurring concepts among the 65 participants from the second study published in 2015*

| Categories coded | Frequency of occurrence during the interviews (f) | Number of participants who mentioned the theme at least once |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|

|                                                                                        |     |    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|----|
| <b>Experience and personal observation</b>                                             | 854 | 65 |
| <b>Structural peace conception (Peace possibility depends upon structural factors)</b> | 476 | 65 |
| <b>Oral conversation</b>                                                               | 462 | 65 |
| <b>Structural violence conception</b>                                                  | 362 | 63 |

Table V. Five most frequently occurring concepts among the 25 workers from Company X

| Categories coded                      | Frequency of occurrence during the interviews (f) | Number of participants who mentioned the theme at least once |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Own Experience and Observation</b> | 368                                               | 25                                                           |
| <b>Structural Peace Conception</b>    | 233                                               | 25                                                           |
| <b>Oral Conversation</b>              | 213                                               | 25                                                           |
| <b>Distrust of Government</b>         | 173                                               | 22                                                           |
| <b>Structural Violence Conception</b> | 168                                               | 25                                                           |

### Searching for variations

As explained above, in this investigation, some precoded categories were added to detect any potential pattern repetitions in the interviews of the 25 people who work in a very favorable environment. These precoded categories were *Situation improving* (any potential mentions by participants indicating that the situation in the country was getting better), *Positive strategy/Government efficiency* (mentions regarding the government applying efficient strategies to build peace) and *Positive experience at work*. No significant results, however, were found regarding those categories. Although *Situation improving* received 38 mentions and was the 16<sup>th</sup> most mentioned category, another category from previous stages of the project, *Situation deteriorating* received almost as many mentions ( $f=37$ ) and even a higher percentage of all mentions (1.37%) than in the previous stage of the project (0.94%). *Positive strategy/Government efficiency* ( $f=9$ ) and *Positive experience at work* ( $f=6$ ) did not receive a sufficient number of mentions to become a pattern. Given all the actions taken by Company X, the latter finding is worthy of notice. This means that when workers were discussing the topics of organized criminal violence and peace, they tended to speak about their experiences, primarily their high-impact experiences with violence, and the experiences of people close to them that occurred in their neighborhoods and on their way to work, whereas mentions of positive labor experiences were largely absent from their conversations. More variations between the different phases of the project and the findings from the present study were explored, but the deviations were minor. For example, mentions regarding *Mass media TV* seemed to occur somewhat more often among the 25 workers of Company X than among the participants in the previous phases of the investigation. In the

present study, it was the 9<sup>th</sup> most frequently mentioned category. However, when analyzing participant conversations, 84% of interviewees say they distrust mass media, which is consistent with the previous study published in 2015, in which 86% of the interviewees expressed the same distrust. Participants have some degree of contact with traditional mass media; however, they seem to distrust what they read, hear, or watch.

### *The fear factor*

The conclusions regarding these comparisons are similar for the category *Fear or terror*. Participants in the present case study repeatedly spoke about the fear and terror they feel due to the violence they experience. This factor was mentioned more often among the interviewees from Company X than among the participants from Mexico City who were interviewed in the previous phases of the investigation. The findings of the present study, however, are rather consistent with the interviews of participants who live outside Mexico's capital. In the second phase of this project, *Fear or terror* was the fourth most frequently occurring category among the participants from 15 other cities within the country, which was consistent with the high levels of violence that those cities are suffering. In the present case study, the same category was the 8<sup>th</sup> most frequently mentioned theme ( $f=113$  or 4.2% of all mentions), with 88% of participants mentioning it at least once. This seems to be related to the experiences they have suffered with high-impact violence ( $f=84$ , 88% of the participants).

Consistent with the findings for other cities within the country, these feelings may be connected to the violence levels present in the State of Mexico, where most of the participants live. In 2014, the State of Mexico was ranked first nationally in intentional homicide reports, kidnappings, extortion, armed robberies, vehicle robberies, household robberies, and business robberies (Sistema Nacional de Seguridad Pública [SNSP], 2016). According to the National Survey of Victimization and Perceptions of Public Safety (ENVPSP, 2016), inhabitants of the State of Mexico feel more insecure than inhabitants of other areas. According to the results of the present study, this may be directly connected to their own experiences or to their conversations. The following are some examples of typical remarks by the participants:

My life has changed; we go out, and we must be prepared for anything; we don't know whether we are going to come back, we don't know whether we will be mugged or shot. So we learn to live in the midst of this; we can't hide, we'd like to build a cave and get inside, but unfortunately, we are in the middle of everything and we must live like this. (Interview participant 5)

You get into a taxi, and you tell them to take you to my neighborhood, and they say they don't go there for fear [...] it's very rare when a taxi driver takes you to my neighborhood. (Interview participant 9)

Sincerely, the only thing you do because of fear and for your safety is you turn away. I tell you, I mean, perhaps if I was alone, and I didn't care, maybe you try to report crimes or do something, but I am not alone, I have my daughters and my wife, and I wouldn't dare

because something could happen to me and they would be left alone, or something could happen to them. (Interview participant 10)

Yes, it's fear of going out because you are never safe anywhere. Where I live, you don't know anyone anymore. If the guy on the corner already has a big house, he built it overnight, well maybe he is a drug dealer now. And on the other side of the street, they arrested the gang that used to join there. Everything is very insecure now. (Interview participant 20)

Everything has become more fearful. If I, for example, live in Coacalco [State of Mexico] which is 20 minutes away from here, and on the streets, in the entrance of that municipality, you can now see the vans of the Navy, and the Army, always there, waiting. So people have to get used to that and adapt. (Interview participant 23)

### **Discussion of Findings: Implications for Public Policy and for Businesses**

As in the previous stages of this project, the main finding of the present study is the consistency in pattern repetitions across gender, age, and income level within Company X. This consistency in pattern repetition is also observed between the present study and the previous two phases of the project. Participants seem to socially construct their values, perceptions, and conceptions of organized crime-related violence and peace from their own experiences and observations, from conversations, and from the experiences of closely related people. In their view, deep-rooted structural factors, such as corruption, income inequality, and lack of education are the main causes of organized criminal violence. They seem to distrust the government and regard it as an inefficient body that colludes with organized crime and sometimes with mass media, which they highly distrust. These patterns were substantially the same in all three phases of the project. More concretely, these patterns seem to be equally present among the interviewed workers of Company X, a corporation regarded as having a very favorable environment in which to work, despite the advantageous labor conditions in which the participants spend a large part of their days. This means that the experiences they have in their daily lives in their neighborhoods and while commuting between those neighborhoods and their workplace, as well as the conversations they have with family and friends about the experiences of closely related people, appear to have a much greater influence on their perceptions of and ideas about violence and peace than any positive experiences they may have at work. These findings lead us to the following implications:

1. Although the results of this study are limited in nature, the literature review above shows that when working in conflictive environments, corporations cannot act alone. Despite offering economic and labor incentives, training, and education programs, as well as taking many other measures to produce a very favorable working atmosphere, when the surrounding environment in which workers live is violent, those incentives may not be enough to produce overall positive peaceful sentiments among a company's workers. More concretely, when organized criminal violence is as high as it is in the State of Mexico (SNSP, 2016), it is likely that the perceptions and conceptions of violence and peace among

citizens will be influenced primarily by the high-impact violence, and not by any positive incentives that the company they work for may provide.

2. Consequently, in such environments, public policy designed to foster peacebuilding at the local level may have to be applied concurrently with corporate incentives and socially responsible measures to positively impact people's perceptions and conceptions of violence and peace.
3. Collaborative projects between the public, private, and social sectors must address both the improvement of working conditions and the level of peace at the local and experiential levels.
4. Corporations working in environments marked by organized criminal violence may have to assess the level of stress this causes among their employees to better help them address stress through the use of specialized tools and workshops, or even psychological first aid and intervention when needed (James, 2004). It is worth noting that in several of the 25 interviews, participants repeatedly thanked the interviewer for devoting time and attention to the workers' issues and concerns. The findings of this study seem to show that those employees may deeply value any measures specifically directed at addressing these areas of attention and concern, perhaps even more than they value other activities that the corporation is conducting.

Future research is suggested that replicates this study in other businesses and areas of Mexico (as well as in other parts in the world) to assess whether the patterns found in this case study tend to repeat. Moreover, the results from the present investigation, together with the results from the other stages of this project, could be used to design a quantitative research tool to determine the validity of the abovementioned implications. Until then, the findings presented here are limited.

## Conclusion

As the third phase of a research project, the present case study sought to explore the same questions investigated in the previous stages through interviews with 25 people who work under favorable conditions; it also sought to determine whether the patterns from the two previous phases would be repeated. The present investigation found that the process of the social construction of values, perceptions, and conceptions regarding organized criminal violence and peace among the 25 participants from the Company X is composed primarily of the same elements that were present in participants from other locations and professions who were interviewed previously (2014; 2015). The lack of significant variations in those results suggest that only a comprehensive approach towards peace—which may involve collaborative efforts between the social sectors of society that address not only the experience of structural peace at work but also seek to foster peace at the local level in neighborhoods where workers live—may be effective in producing a change in workers' perceptions regarding organized criminal violence and the possibilities for peace in their country.

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